GC interview transcript with Kevin Chen

Kevin is an assistant PM and he prefers to do the interview in Chinese. The translation will be after the mandarin interview transcript.

Vincent：您好，非常感谢您今天抽时间跟我们聊。我叫 Vincent，是 University of Washington 的学生。我们的 capstone 课程在研究 subcontractor 和 GC 之间的 RFI 是怎么写、怎么 review 的，以及在 RFI 发出去之前用 AI 检查一下，能不能让 GC 的 review 更快。

Kevin：不客气，这段时间不算太忙，能帮上忙挺好的。

Vincent：开始之前想跟您确认一下：我们可以录音吗？录音只用来整理一份文字记录。我们会去掉您的公司名字，翻译成英文后放到我们课程项目的 GitHub 里。任何问题您都可以不回答，也可以随时停止。

Kevin：可以，录吧，公司去掉就行。有些项目细节我会说得模糊一点，毕竟涉及业主的信息。

Vincent：再确认一下：您同意我们录音，并把英文文字稿用在课程项目里吗？

Kevin：同意。

Vincent：可以先简单介绍一下您现在的工作吗？

Kevin：好。我在圣路易斯一家华人开的建筑公司，十几个人，做总包。我是 assistant project manager，也就是助理项目经理，入行差不多三年。

我们的活主要两类。一类是商业的，餐馆和店面装修，也就是 tenant improvement，很多在 Olive Blvd 那一带，业主不少是开中餐馆、奶茶店、亚洲超市的华人。另一类是住宅翻新，圣路易斯 city 里一百年左右的老砖房很多，翻新的时候问题特别多。

我平时跟着 PM 跑项目：盯 sub 的进度，处理 submittal 和 RFI，跟建筑师、业主沟通，约 inspection。最近一年开始自己带一些小项目，大概二三十万美元的餐馆装修。

Vincent：您对处理 RFI 是不是已经非常熟悉了？

Kevin：非常熟悉不敢说哈哈哈。三年下来经手的 RFI 大概两三百条，我们公司的 RFI 基本都是我在整理，所以流程上是熟的。但我做的大多是小项目，跟几千万美元的学校、医院项目比，量和规范程度都差很多。

Vincent：在您公司，一条 RFI 从 subcontractor 写出来，到最后拿到答复，中间大概是什么流程？

Kevin：要看项目。商业项目一般有建筑师，比较正规。sub 在现场发现问题，比如图纸上两个东西打架，或者现场跟图不一样，就先发给我。说实话，很多时候不是正式的 RFI，就是一条微信或者短信，拍张照片，问“这里怎么弄”。

我们的 sub 一半华人一半本地美国人。华人 sub 基本发微信，美国 sub 发短信或者 email。

我收到以后先判断这个问题我们自己能不能答。施工顺序、现场协调这类，我跟 PM 商量一下就直接回了，不走 RFI。如果是设计上的问题，比如尺寸对不上、图纸之间矛盾、需要改做法，就要正式发给建筑师。

这时候我把它整理成正式的 RFI：编号，写清楚问题，标上图号和位置，附照片，有时候加上我们建议的做法。然后录进我们的 RFI log，email 发给建筑师。合同里一般写建筑师 7 到 10 天回复，实际上快的两三天，慢的两三个星期。

回复回来以后，我转给相关的 sub，更新 log。如果回复改了做法，牵涉到钱或者工期，可能就变成 change order，那是另一套流程。

住宅翻新简单很多。很多项目没有建筑师，有问题直接打电话问业主，结构上的事找结构工程师确认，基本没有正式的 RFI。

Vincent：你们用什么软件或者固定的 form 来处理 RFI 吗？比如 Procore？

Kevin：我们自己没买 Procore，对我们这个规模来说太贵。我们就是一个 Excel 的 RFI log，加一个 Word 的 RFI 模板，模板是照着 AIA G716 的格式改的。看图和标注用 Bluebeam。

例外是一个连锁餐饮品牌的项目，业主那边用 Procore，我们就在他们的系统里发。但 sub 一般没有账号，所以还是 sub 发给我，我再录进去。

所以说实话，sub 自己写的 RFI 很少能直接用，大部分都要经过我这一手。

Vincent：那我想问一下，在您打开一条 subcontractor 发来的 RFI的时候，第一件事会先看什么？

Kevin：第一件事是看它是不是一个真正的问题，哈哈哈。有一部分 RFI，答案其实图纸上就有，sub 没仔细看，或者看的是旧版的图。所以我先翻图，看有没有现成的答案。

第二是看位置和图号：说的是哪张图、哪个 detail、现场哪个位置。这个对不上，后面没法看。

第三是看它有没有在“埋钱”。有的 sub 会用 RFI 给后面的 change order 铺路，比如写“图上没有显示 XX，请确认是否需要”，意思其实是“这不在我的合同范围里，要加钱”。这种我要跟 PM 对一下合同。

最后看急不急，就是这个问题会不会卡住现场的活。

Vincent：第一次 review 一般要花多长时间？什么情况会让它变快或者变慢？

Kevin：简单的五到十分钟。sub 写得清楚，图号对，有照片，还写了建议做法，我对一下图，没问题就整理发出去了。

复杂的半小时到一小时，有时候还要跑一趟现场。变慢主要有几个原因：

首先主要是位置说不清。比如“厨房墙上那个插座”，厨房里十几个插座，到底是哪个？
然后是图号写错，或者引用的是旧版的图。我们项目中间经常出 revision，sub 手上可能还是 bid 那套图。有的时候一条 RFI 问了好几个问题，我得拆开，有的我能答，有的要发给建筑师。当然还

有的时候是语言。很多华人 sub 英文写不好，有的直接写中文，我得翻成正式的英文再发给建筑师。这个挺花时间，翻的时候还得确认我理解对了他的意思。
变快就是反过来：图号对，有照片，有标注，有建议做法。照片特别重要，一张照片画个箭头，比写一段话清楚多了。

Vincent：您会因为信息缺失或者问题不清楚，把 RFI 退回给 subcontractor吗？

Kevin：正式“退回”的不多，但需要回头去问 sub 的，我估计四条里有一条左右。也跟 sub 有关系，合作久的老 sub 写得清楚，新的或者小的 sub 问题多一些。

很多时候我不退回，直接打电话问。退回去他再写一遍，来回又是一两天；打电话五分钟就问清楚了，然后我自己帮他补上。

Vincent：能举个例子吗？

Kevin：有个餐馆项目，水管工发微信说：“floor sink 位置不对，跟图不一样，怎么办？”就这一句，加一张很近的照片，只看得到地上切开的混凝土。

厨房里有好几个 floor sink，我不知道他说的是哪个；“跟图不一样”是哪张图，也不知道；到底是跟设备对不上，还是下面碰到了东西，也不清楚。

电话没打通，第二天我去现场才搞清楚：是三格水槽下面那个 floor sink，按图的位置切开以后，下面正好有一个老的基础，没法往下挖。

Vincent：退回去之后通常会怎样？

Kevin：那次是我到现场跟他一起量尺寸、拍照，在 Bluebeam 上把位置标出来，然后我自己写成 RFI 发给建筑师，附了一个建议：往旁边挪 18 寸。建筑师跟 MEP 工程师确认以后，五天后回复同意。

一般来说，退回或者打电话问会耽误一两天。如果让 sub 自己重写，有时候他会拖，因为他觉得写 RFI 是文书工作，不是他的本行。所以很多时候最后还是我来写。

Vincent：那 RFI 里最常缺的是什么信息？比如位置、图号、需要回复的时间，还是对施工的影响？

Kevin：最常缺的是位置，其次是 deadline 和 impact。

位置刚才说了。sub 人在现场，觉得“这里”很清楚，但看 RFI 的人不在现场。最好写房间号、轴线，或者直接在图上标出来。

Deadline 基本没人写，要不就全写 ASAP。全部都是 ASAP，就等于没有 ASAP。我们最需要知道的是：这个问题最晚哪天要答复，不然哪天现场就得停。

Impact 也很少有人写，比如“不改会怎么样”、“会不会影响工期、要不要加钱”。这个对建筑师排优先级很重要，对我们控制 change order 也很重要。

图号反而还好，大部分 sub 至少会写个图号，就是经常写不准。

Vincent：RFI 里的 drawing reference 或者 spec reference 写错或者没写的情况多吗？遇到的时候您怎么处理？

Kevin：挺多的，我粗略估计十条里有两三条有问题,比如说会有引用旧版本的情况。比如 A-201 后来出了 revision，他用的还是 bid set。或者图号写不全或写错。比如写“A2”，到底是 A-201 还是 A-202 不知道；或者 detail 写错，“5/A-501”写成“5/A-50”。

我的处理办法是：能看出来他指的是哪张，我就直接改好再发给建筑师。因为 RFI 是以我们 GC 的名义发出去的，图号写错，建筑师会觉得我们不专业，有时候直接退回来，又浪费一个来回。看不出来，就打电话问。

Vincent：您有没有遇到过哪条 RFI 导致项目延误的？当时是哪里出了问题？

Kevin：有。印象最深的是去年一个餐馆项目，厨房排油烟的风管。

机械 sub 发了一条 RFI，问“hood exhaust duct 穿屋顶的位置能不能调整”，但没写为什么要调，也没附照片。建筑师就回了一句 per plan，按图施工。

等到真要开洞才发现，图上的位置正好跟屋顶的一根 joist 打架，按图做就得切 joist。这就变成结构问题了。又发了第二条 RFI，建筑师再找结构工程师出方案，前后等了差不多两个星期。

这两个星期风管装不了，above-ceiling inspection 约不了，天花板也封不了，后面的工序全往后推。最后开业推迟了十天左右。业主很不高兴，人已经招好了，房租也一直在付。

回头看，问题出在第一条 RFI。如果当时写清楚为什么要调，也就是跟 joist 冲突，再附一张照片，建筑师第一次就会去找结构工程师，至少省一个来回。另外也没写 deadline，建筑师不知道这件事这么急。

Vincent：我们现在的项目数据来自芝加哥一个公开的学校项目。我们用的是 bid 阶段的问题，再改写成 subcontractor 发给 GC 的 RFI。您觉得这样真实吗？跟施工阶段真正的 RFI 比，会有什么不一样？

Kevin：思路我能理解，施工阶段的 RFI 一般不公开，很难拿到。但两种确实差挺多。

Bid 阶段的问题大多在问范围和数量，比如“这个包不包含在我们的 scope 里”、“能不能用替代产品”、“图纸和 spec 不一致以哪个为准”。问的人还没进场，都是看图看出来的问题。

施工阶段的 RFI 很多是现场发现的：墙打开跟图不一样，两个工种打架，设备到了尺寸不对。所以真实的 RFI 会有现场照片，有急不急的问题，也会牵涉到钱和工期。

写法也不一样。Bid 阶段的问题一般是 estimator 在办公室写的，比较规范。施工阶段 sub 发给 GC 的 RFI，很多是 foreman 在现场用手机打的，错字、缩写、半句话都有，有时候就一张照片加一句话。你们改写过的数据，可能比真实的干净很多。

还有，学校是公共项目，规模大、流程正规，大概率用 Procore 这类系统，跟我们小公司的情况差别也大。只用这套数据的话，可能会高估 RFI 的规范程度。

Vincent：那假设有一个工具，在 subcontractor 把 RFI 发给您之前，先检查有没有缺信息、图号对不对。您会信任它吗？为什么？

Kevin：如果它只是检查和提醒，我觉得可以信任，相当于一个 checklist。比如提醒 sub“你没写位置”、“A-205 在最新的图纸里没有”，这个挺有用。

但有几个前提。第一，它用的必须是最新版的图纸，图纸一更新它就得跟着更新，不然它说的“图号不对”本身就是错的。第二，它要说明理由，比如“在最新的 sheet index 里找不到 A-205”，让我能自己核对，而不是只打一个红叉。第三，最后的判断还是人来做。

还有个实际问题：谁来用？我们很多 sub 的 foreman 年纪比较大，让他再装一个 app、注册账号，大概率不会用。如果能在我这边用，sub 发给我以后我一键检查，可能更现实。

Vincent：如果这个工具有时候会误报，比如说某张图不存在，但其实是存在的，您会怎么做？

Kevin：偶尔误报能接受，我自己再查一下就行。但误报多了，比如十次里错三次，大家很快就不看了，到时候它报对了我们也不会管了。

感觉吧误报对 sub 的影响可能更大。sub 看到“图不存在”，可能以为自己拿的是旧图，然后改成一个错的图号，比原来还麻烦。所以提示的语气要谨慎，比如“在当前图纸目录里没有找到这张图，请确认”，而不是直接说“这张图不存在”。最好还有个按钮能标记“这个提醒是错的”，让它慢慢改进。

Vincent：我们的目标是让 GC 的第一次 review 至少快 25%，同时不增加新的错误。这对您的工作会有实际帮助吗？还有什么也需要改进？

Kevin：有帮助，但说句实话，第一次 review 本身花的时间不是最大的问题。一条简单的 RFI 我看十分钟，快 25% 也就省两三分钟。

真正花时间的是来回。RFI 不完整，我打电话、等回复、跑现场，一来一回就是一两天，建筑师那边再等一个星期。所以你们的工具如果能让 RFI 第一次就写完整、少一个来回，省的是天，不是分钟。我建议你们除了 review 时间，也看看来回次数，或者从 sub 发出到拿到答复的总时间。

还有两个我觉得有用的方向。一个是帮华人 sub 把中文的问题整理成规范的英文 RFI，这对我们这种公司特别实用。另一个是直接跟 RFI log 连起来，自动编号、自动记录，不用我再手动录一遍。

Vincent：好的，非常谢谢你，关于 RFI的采访我基本上没有其他问题了。非常感谢您的时间，这对我们的项目帮助很大！

Kevin：好的，有问题发邮件就行。**Vincent**：太好了，再次感谢！

Translation:

Vincent: Hello, thank you so much for taking the time to talk with us today. My name is Vincent, and I’m a student at the University of Washington. Our capstone course is studying how RFIs between

subcontractors and GCs are written and reviewed, and whether using AI to check an RFI before it is sent could make the GC's review faster.

Kevin: You're welcome. I'm not too busy right now, so I'm happy to help.

Vincent: Before we start, I want to confirm: can we record this? The recording will only be used to make a written transcript. We'll remove your name and company, translate it into English, and put it in our course project's GitHub. You can skip any question and stop at any time.

Kevin: Sure, go ahead and record. Just remove the company name. I'll keep some project details vague, since they involve owners' information.

Vincent: Just to confirm again: do you agree to us recording and using the English transcript in our course project?

Kevin: I agree.

Vincent: Could you briefly introduce your current work?

Kevin: Sure. I work at a Chinese-owned construction company in St. Louis, with a dozen or so people. We're a general contractor. I'm an assistant project manager, and I've been in the industry for about three years.

Our work is mainly two types. One is commercial: restaurant and storefront renovations, that is, tenant improvements, many of them along Olive Blvd. Quite a few owners are Chinese, running Chinese restaurants, bubble tea shops, and Asian supermarkets. The other type is residential renovation. The city of St. Louis has many old brick houses, around a hundred years old, and renovating them brings a lot of problems.

I usually work alongside the PM on projects: tracking subcontractor progress, handling submittals and RFIs, communicating with architects and owners, and scheduling inspections. In the past year, I've started leading some small projects on my own, mostly restaurant renovations of around $200,000 to $300,000.

Vincent: Would you say you're already very familiar with handling RFIs?

Kevin: I wouldn't say *very* familiar (laughs). In three years, I've handled roughly two to three hundred RFIs. I organize almost all of our company's RFIs, so I know the process well. But most of my work is on small projects. Compared with school or hospital projects worth tens of millions of dollars, the volume and level of formality are very different.

Vincent: At your company, what is the process for an RFI, from when a subcontractor writes it to when it finally gets an answer?

Kevin: It depends on the project. Commercial projects usually have an architect, so they're more formal. A sub finds a problem on site, for example two things on the drawings clash, or the site doesn't match

the drawings, and they send it to me first. Honestly, a lot of the time it's not a formal RFI. It's just a WeChat message or a text with a photo, asking "how do I do this?"

About half of our subs are Chinese and half are local Americans. The Chinese subs mostly use WeChat; the American subs send texts or emails. When I receive it, I first decide whether we can answer it ourselves. Things like construction sequence or site coordination, I discuss with the PM and reply directly, without an RFI. If it's a design issue, for example dimensions don't match, drawings contradict each other, or the method needs to change, then it has to go formally to the architect.

Then I turn it into a formal RFI: give it a number, write the question clearly, add the drawing number and location, attach photos, and sometimes add our suggested solution. Then I enter it into our RFI log and email it to the architect. The contract usually says the architect replies in 7 to 10 days. In reality, fast ones take two or three days, and slow ones take two or three weeks.

When the answer comes back, I forward it to the relevant sub and update the log. If the answer changes the work method and affects cost or schedule, it may become a change order, which is a separate process.

Residential renovation is much simpler. Many of those projects have no architect. If there's a problem, we call the owner directly, and for structural issues we ask a structural engineer to confirm. There are basically no formal RFIs.

Vincent: Do you use any software or a standard form for RFIs, like Procore?

Kevin: We didn't buy Procore ourselves. It's too expensive for a company our size. We just use an Excel RFI log and a Word RFI template based on the AIA G716 format. We use Bluebeam to view and mark up drawings.

The exception was a project for a restaurant chain. The owner used Procore, so we submitted RFIs in their system. But subs usually don't have accounts, so the sub still sends it to me, and I enter it.

So honestly, RFIs that subs write themselves are rarely usable as is. Most of them go through me.

Vincent: When you open an RFI from a subcontractor, what is the first thing you check?

Kevin: The first thing is whether it's actually a real question, haha. For some RFIs, the answer is already on the drawings. The sub didn't look carefully, or they were looking at an old version of the drawings. So first I check the drawings to see if the answer is already there.

Second, I check the location and drawing number: which drawing, which detail, and where on site. If these don't match, I can't review the rest.

Third, I check whether it's "hiding money." Some subs use RFIs to set up a future change order. For example, they write "the drawings do not show XX, please confirm whether it is required," which really means "this isn't in my contract scope, so it will cost extra." For those, I check the contract with the PM.

Finally, I look at how urgent it is, meaning whether the question will hold up work on site.

Vincent: How long does a first review usually take? What makes it faster or slower?

Kevin: A simple one takes five to ten minutes. If the sub wrote it clearly, the drawing number is right, there are photos, and they included a suggested solution, I check it against the drawings, and if it's fine, I write it up and send it.

A complicated one takes half an hour to an hour, and sometimes I have to go to the site. The main reasons it gets slower are:

First, the location isn't clear. For example, "the outlet on the kitchen wall." There are a dozen outlets in the kitchen. Which one?

Second, the drawing number is wrong, or it refers to an old version. Our projects often get revisions partway through, and the sub might still have the bid set. Sometimes one RFI asks several questions, and I have to split them up: some I can answer, some have to go to the architect. And sometimes it's language. Many Chinese subs don't write English well, and some write directly in Chinese. I have to translate it into formal English before sending it to the architect. That takes a lot of time, and while translating, I also have to make sure I understood what they meant.

Faster is the opposite: the drawing number is right, and there are photos, markups, and a suggested solution. Photos are especially important. One photo with an arrow is much clearer than a paragraph of text.

Vincent: Do you send RFIs back to subcontractors because information is missing or the question is unclear?

Kevin: I don't formally "send back" many, but I'd estimate about one in four needs me to go back and ask the sub. It also depends on the sub. Experienced subs we've worked with for a long time write clearly; new or small subs have more problems.

A lot of the time I don't send it back. I just call. If I send it back, they rewrite it, and that's another one or two days. A phone call clears it up in five minutes, and then I fill in the missing parts myself.

Vincent: Could you give an example?

Kevin: On one restaurant project, the plumber sent a WeChat message: "The floor sink location is wrong, it doesn't match the drawings, what should I do?" That was it, plus one very close-up photo that only showed the cut concrete on the floor.

There were several floor sinks in the kitchen, so I didn't know which one he meant. "Doesn't match the drawings": which drawing? I didn't know. I also couldn't tell whether it didn't fit the equipment or whether it hit something underneath.

I couldn't reach him by phone. The next day I went to the site and figured it out: it was the floor sink under the three-compartment sink. When they cut the concrete at the location on the drawings, there was an old footing right underneath, so they couldn't dig down.

Vincent: What usually happens after you send it back?

Kevin: That time, I went to the site, measured with him, took photos, and marked the location in Bluebeam. Then I wrote the RFI myself and sent it to the architect, with a suggestion: move it 18 inches to the side. The architect confirmed with the MEP engineer and approved it five days later.

In general, sending it back or calling delays things by a day or two. If I ask the sub to rewrite it, sometimes they put it off, because they think writing RFIs is paperwork and not their job. So a lot of the time, I end up writing it myself.

Vincent: What information is most often missing from an RFI? For example, location, drawing number, response deadline, or impact on the work?

Kevin: The most commonly missing is location, then deadline and impact.

I already mentioned location. The sub is on site, so “here” seems obvious to them, but the person reading the RFI isn’t on site. It’s best to write the room number or grid line, or mark it directly on the drawing.

Almost nobody writes a deadline, or they write ASAP on everything. If everything is ASAP, then nothing is ASAP. What we most need to know is the latest date this question must be answered before work on site has to stop.

Impact is rarely written either, for example “what happens if this doesn’t change” or “will this affect the schedule or cost more.” That’s very important for the architect to set priorities, and for us to control change orders.

Drawing numbers are actually not as bad. Most subs at least write a drawing number. It’s just often not accurate.

Vincent: Are drawing or spec references in RFIs often wrong or missing? How do you handle it?

Kevin: Quite often. I’d roughly estimate two or three out of ten have a problem. For example, they reference an old version: A-201 was revised later, but they’re still using the bid set. Or the drawing number is incomplete or wrong. For example, they write “A2,” and I don’t know if it’s A-201 or A-202. Or the detail is wrong, like “5/A-501” written as “5/A-50.”

How I handle it: if I can tell which drawing they mean, I fix it myself before sending it to the architect. The RFI goes out under our GC’s name, so if the drawing number is wrong, the architect thinks we’re unprofessional, and sometimes they send it straight back, which wastes another round. If I can’t tell, I call.

Vincent: Have you had an RFI that caused a project delay? What went wrong?

Kevin: Yes. The one I remember most was a restaurant project last year, with the kitchen exhaust duct.

The mechanical sub sent an RFI asking “can the location where the hood exhaust duct goes through the roof be adjusted?” But they didn’t say why it needed to be adjusted and didn’t attach a photo. The architect just replied “per plan,” meaning build it as drawn.

When it was time to cut the opening, they found that the location on the drawings clashed with a roof joist. Building it as drawn meant cutting the joist. So it became a structural issue. They sent a second RFI, and the architect had the structural engineer come up with a solution. It took almost two weeks in total.

During those two weeks, the duct couldn’t be installed, the above-ceiling inspection couldn’t be scheduled, and the ceiling couldn’t be closed, so everything after that was pushed back. In the end, the restaurant opening was delayed by about ten days. The owner was very unhappy, because they had already hired staff and were paying rent the whole time.

Looking back, the problem was the first RFI. If it had clearly said why the duct needed to move, that it clashed with the joist, and included a photo, the architect would have gone to the structural engineer the first time, saving at least one round. It also didn’t have a deadline, so the architect didn’t know it was so urgent.

Vincent: Our project data comes from a public school project in Chicago. We used bid-stage questions and rewrote them as subcontractor-to-GC RFIs. Do you think that’s realistic? Compared with real construction-stage RFIs, what would be different?

Kevin: I understand the idea. Construction-stage RFIs are usually not public, so they’re hard to get. But the two are quite different.

Bid-stage questions mostly ask about scope and quantities, for example “is this included in our scope?”, “can we use a substitute product?”, or “the drawings and spec don’t match, which one governs?” The people asking haven’t started work on site yet. These are all problems found by reading the drawings.

Many construction-stage RFIs are found on site: you open a wall and it doesn’t match the drawings, two trades clash, or equipment arrives and the size is wrong. So real RFIs have site photos, urgency, and they often involve cost and schedule.

The writing is also different. Bid-stage questions are usually written by an estimator in the office, so they’re fairly formal. Construction-stage RFIs from a sub to a GC are often typed by a foreman on a phone on site, with typos, abbreviations, and half sentences. Sometimes it’s just one photo and one sentence. Your rewritten data is probably much cleaner than real RFIs.

Also, a school is a public project, large in scale with formal processes, and probably uses a system like Procore. That’s very different from a small company like ours. If you only use this dataset, you might overestimate how well-written RFIs are.

Vincent: Suppose there is a tool that checks for missing information and whether drawing numbers are correct before the subcontractor sends the RFI to you. Would you trust it? Why?

Kevin: If it only checks and reminds, I think I could trust it. It's like a checklist. For example, reminding the sub "you didn't write the location" or "A-205 is not in the latest drawings." That's quite useful.

But there are a few conditions. First, it must use the latest drawings, and it has to update whenever the drawings are updated. Otherwise, its claim that "the drawing number is wrong" could itself be wrong. Second, it needs to explain its reason, for example "A-205 was not found in the latest sheet index," so I can check it myself, instead of just showing a red X. Third, the final decision is still made by a person.

There's also a practical question: who will use it? Many of our subs' foremen are older. If you ask them to install another app and register an account, they probably won't use it. If I could use it on my side, so that when a sub sends something to me, I check it with one click, that might be more realistic.

Vincent: If the tool sometimes gives false alarms, for example saying a drawing doesn't exist when it actually does, what would you do?

Kevin: An occasional false alarm is acceptable. I'd just check it again myself. But if there are too many, say three wrong out of ten, people will quickly stop looking at it. Then even when it's right, we won't pay attention.

I feel false alarms might affect subs even more. If a sub sees "this drawing doesn't exist," they might think they have old drawings and change it to a wrong drawing number, which is even more trouble than before. So the wording of the alert should be careful, for example "this drawing was not found in the current drawing index, please confirm," rather than "this drawing does not exist." It would be best to also have a button to mark "this alert is wrong," so the tool can improve over time.

Vincent: Our goal is to make the GC's first review at least 25% faster without adding new errors. Would that really help your work? What else needs to improve?

Kevin: It would help, but honestly, the first review itself isn't the biggest time cost. I spend ten minutes on a simple RFI. Making it 25% faster only saves two or three minutes.

What really takes time is the back-and-forth. If an RFI is incomplete, I call, wait for a reply, go to the site, and one round takes a day or two. Then the architect takes another week. So if your tool can help get the RFI complete the first time and avoid one round, it saves days, not minutes. I'd suggest that besides review time, you also look at the number of back-and-forth rounds, or the total time from when the sub sends it to when they get an answer.

There are two other directions I think would be useful. One is helping Chinese subs turn questions written in Chinese into formal English RFIs. That would be really practical for a company like ours. The other is connecting directly to the RFI log, with automatic numbering and recording, so I don't have to enter everything manually again.

Vincent: Great, thank you so much. I don't have any more questions about RFIs. Thank you very much for your time. This is a big help for our project!

Kevin: Sure. If you have any questions, just email me.

Vincent: Great, thanks again!